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Note that the acceleration depends on the angle of inclination θ. If the angle θ is 90 degree, the block will move vertically with acceleration $a = g$.

Newton's kinematic equation is used to find the speed of the object when it reaches the bottom. The acceleration is constant throughout the motion.

$$v^2 = u^2 + 2as \text{ along the x direction} \quad (3.3)$$

The acceleration a is equal to g sinθ. The initial speed (u) is equal to zero as it starts from rest. Here s is the length of the inclined surface.

The speed (v) when it reaches the bottom is (using equation (3.3))

$$v = \sqrt{2sg\ sin\theta} \quad (3.4)$$

Note Here we choose the coordinate system along the inclined plane. Even if we choose the coordinate system parallel to the horizontal surface, we will get the same result. But the mathematics will be quite complicated. Choosing a suitable inertial coordinate system for the given problem is very important.

3.3.3 Two Bodies in Contact on a Horizontal Surface

Consider two blocks of masses m_1 and m_2 ($m_1 > m_2$) kept in contact with each other on a smooth, horizontal frictionless surface as shown in Figure 3.14.

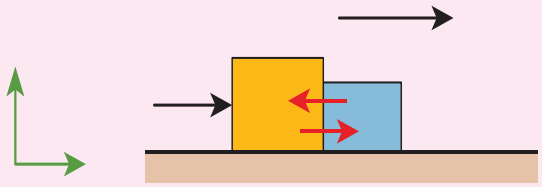


Figure 3.14 (a) Two blocks of masses m_1 and m_2 ($m_1 > m_2$) kept in contact with each other on a smooth, horizontal frictionless surface

By the application of a horizontal force F, both the blocks are set into motion with acceleration 'a' simultaneously in the direction of the force F.

To find the acceleration $\vec{a}$, Newton's second law has to be applied to the system (combined mass $m = m_1 + m_2$)

$$\vec{F} = m\vec{a}$$

If we choose the motion of the two masses along the positive x direction,

$$F\hat{i} = ma\hat{i}$$

By comparing components on both sides of the above equation

$$F = ma \quad \text{where } m = m_1 + m_2$$

The acceleration of the system is given by

$$\therefore a = \frac{F}{m_1 + m_2} \quad (3.5)$$